Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 4.1 Guided Notes: Attribution Theory and Person Perception

Unit 4: Social Psychology and Personality | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic4.1

Word Bank

Optimistic Explanatory Style	*Mere Exposure Effect*	*Upward Comparison*
Pessimistic Explanatory Style	*External Locus of Control*	*Attributions*
Situational Attributions	*Dispositional Attributions*	*Self-Fulfilling Prophecy*
Downward Comparison	*Relative Deprivation*	*Self-Serving Bias*
Locus of Control	*Person Perception*	*Actor-Observer Bias*
Fundamental Attribution Error	*Internal Locus of Control*	*Explanatory Style*
Social Comparison		

1. Attribution Theory: Why Did They Do That?

Humans are natural detectives. When we see someone act a certain way, we immediately try to figure out why. _____ are how people explain behavior and mental processes of themselves and others. Broadly speaking, there are two main ways we can categorize these explanations:

- _____: These relate to the internal qualities of others, such as intelligence or personality. (e.g., If your classmate trips in the hallway, you might think, “Wow, they are so clumsy.”)
- _____: These relate to external circumstances that are experienced. (e.g., If your classmate trips, you might instead think, “The janitor must have mopped the floor and left it slippery.”)

Explanatory Style

Over time, people demonstrate a predictable pattern of attributions called _____. This pattern is how people explain good and bad events in their lives and in the lives of others, and it can generally be divided into two camps:

- _____: Viewing negative events as temporary, specific, and external, while viewing positive events as stable and personal. (e.g., “I failed this math test because the room was loud, but I'm still a smart student who will ace the next one.”)
- _____: Viewing negative events as permanent, widespread, and internal. (e.g., “I failed this math test because I am inherently bad at school, and I will always be a failure.”)

Apply It: Which Attribution or Explanatory Style?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	When a classmate forgets to return a borrowed book, a student concludes, “She's so irresponsible, and she never cares about other people's stuff.”	
2	When the same classmate forgets the book, another student thinks, “She's been out sick all week, so she probably hasn't even been home to look for it.”	
3	After his team's loss, a goalie thinks, “The field was soaked and everyone struggled today. That's temporary, and I know I'm a good goalie who will bounce back.”	
4	After forgetting a line in the school play, a girl thinks, “I always ruin everything, and it's going to be like this forever, because I'm just a terrible actor.”	

2. Locus of Control

Closely tied to our explanatory style is our _____, which represents how much influence we believe we have over the events in our lives.

- _____: The belief that one's own actions, choices, and efforts are the primary causes of life outcomes. (e.g., “If I study hard and go to practice, I will make the varsity team.”)
- _____: The belief that outcomes are determined by outside forces such as luck, fate, or other people, rather than one's own actions. (e.g., “It doesn't matter how hard I practice; the coach already has his favorites.”)

Apply It: Internal or External?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	After failing his driving test, a teen says, “I didn't practice parallel parking enough. If I put in more practice, I'll pass next time.”	
2	A worker passed over for a promotion says, “It's all luck and office politics, so there's no point in working extra hours.”	

3. Cognitive Biases in Attribution

Because we have to make snap judgments constantly, our brains rely on shortcuts. Unfortunately, people are subject to biases in their attributions. These cognitive blind spots can heavily affect our behavior and mental processes:

- _____: The tendency to overestimate the influence of personal traits and underestimate situational factors when explaining other people's behavior. (e.g., When someone cuts you off in traffic, you assume they are a terrible, selfish person (dispositional), ignoring the possibility that they might be rushing to the hospital for an emergency (situational).)

- _____: A social perception error in which people attribute their own behavior to situational factors but attribute others' behavior to internal traits or dispositions. (e.g., When you do poorly on a project, it's because the teacher gave bad instructions. When your partner does poorly, it's because they are lazy.)
- _____: The tendency to attribute successes to internal factors (such as ability or effort) and failures to external factors (such as luck or circumstances) to protect self-esteem. (e.g., A quarterback wins the game and praises his own incredible arm strength. The next week he loses and blames the referees.)

💡 *Note: The infographic on the study guide page uses the word personality to contrast with situational factors, but AP Psychology frequently refers to this as making a dispositional attribution.*

Apply It: Which Attribution Bias?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A man watches a stranger yell at a barista and concludes the stranger is an angry, hostile person, never considering that he may have just received terrible news.	
2	A student explains that she was late to class because of a train delay, but says her friend was late because “she's just disorganized.”	
3	After winning the science fair, a girl credits her brilliant mind and hard work, but after losing the next year, she blames the judges' unfair scoring.	

4. Person Perception

Beyond assigning blame or praise, _____ involves forming impressions and making judgments about other people based on their appearance, behavior, and available information. This perception applies to behavior and mental processes in several fascinating ways:

- _____: People's perception of how much they like something can be influenced by this effect. It occurs when people are exposed to a stimulus repeatedly over time, which causes them to like the stimulus more. (e.g., You hate a new song on the radio at first, but after hearing it play in the background for a month, you catch yourself happily singing along.)
- _____: People can behave in ways that elicit behaviors from others that confirm their beliefs or perceptions about themselves or others. (e.g., A teacher believes a student is highly gifted, so they give that student extra attention and harder challenges. The student thrives under the attention, proving the teacher “right.”)
- _____: A type of person perception that occurs when people evaluate themselves based on comparisons to other members of society or social circles. This comparison comes in two directions: _____ (comparing yourself to someone better off, which can motivate you or make you feel inadequate) and _____ (comparing yourself to someone worse off to boost your self-esteem).
- _____: People often judge their own sense of deprivation relative to others. (e.g., You might be thrilled with your 5% raise at work until you find out your coworker received a 10% raise. Suddenly, you feel cheated, even though your actual financial situation improved.)

Apply It: Which Person Perception Concept?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A shopper who dislikes an unfamiliar brand of cereal at first begins to prefer it after seeing its ads on nearly every show she watches for several months.	
2	A coach who believes a new player is a natural leader gives him extra responsibility and encouragement, and the player grows into the leadership role the coach predicted.	
3	Scrolling through photos of friends' vacations, a student feels discouraged about her own weekend plans.	
4	A runner who finished last in a race consoles himself by thinking, "At least I finished; lots of people didn't even try."	
5	A family that was happy with their modest apartment grows dissatisfied after moving next door to neighbors who have a pool and a bigger house, even though nothing about their own home has changed.	

5. Don't Trip Up! (Common Misconceptions)

⚠️ Fundamental Attribution Error vs. Actor-Observer Bias: Students frequently confuse these two concepts on the exam. Remember: The _____ is strictly about how you judge others. The _____ is a comparison of how you judge yourself (the actor) versus how you judge someone else (the observer) in a similar situation.

📺 *Video Notes: "Social Thinking" (Crash Course Psychology #37)*

This video covers more than today's topic. Only the first part (social psychology's focus, attribution theory, and the fundamental attribution error, up to about 3:18) matches Topic 4.1. The rest of the video (persuasion, the foot-in-the-door phenomenon, the Stanford Prison Experiment, and cognitive dissonance) belongs to Topics 4.2 and 4.3, so you can stop the video at about 3:18 for now. Answer the questions below on the part that matches today's material.

1. According to the video, what does social psychology focus on, and how does that differ from sub-fields like cognitive, personality, and clinical psychology?

2. What does attribution theory suggest, who began developing it, and how does the video use Bruno at the party to show how hard it can be to tell the two kinds of explanations apart?

3. What is the fundamental attribution error, according to the video, and how can making it affect our opinion of another person?

4. What real-world consequences of how we explain other people's behavior does the video give?

6. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. After watching a coworker snap angrily at a customer, a man immediately concludes, "Wow, she must just be a rude and unpleasant person," without considering that she might be having an unusually difficult day. This explanation, which focuses on the coworker's internal personality traits, is called a:

- **A.** Self-Serving Bias
- **B.** Situational Attribution
- **C.** Relative Deprivation
- **D.** Dispositional Attribution

2. After bombing an important job interview, a woman tells herself, "The interviewer just seemed to be in a bad mood today, but I know I'm still highly qualified and will definitely nail the next one." This tendency to view negative events as temporary and external while viewing positive events as stable and personal is called:

- **A.** Optimistic Explanatory Style
- **B.** External Locus of Control
- **C.** Pessimistic Explanatory Style
- **D.** Internal Locus of Control

3. A frustrated athlete complains, "It doesn't matter how hard I train or how many hours I put into practice, the coach already has his favorites picked out, so I'll never actually make the team no matter what I do." This belief, which places responsibility for outcomes on outside forces, is called an:

- **A.** Self-Serving Bias
- **B.** Internal Locus of Control
- **C.** Pessimistic Explanatory Style Only
- **D.** External Locus of Control

4. When another driver cuts a man off aggressively in traffic, he immediately assumes the other driver must be a rude, reckless, and inconsiderate person, without ever considering that the driver might actually be rushing to the hospital for a genuine emergency. This tendency to overestimate personal traits and underestimate situational factors when judging others is called the:

- **A.** Fundamental Attribution Error
- **B.** Actor-Observer Bias
- **C.** Self-Serving Bias
- **D.** Mere Exposure Effect

5. When a student does poorly on a group project, she blames it on her teacher's confusing and unclear instructions, but when her project partner does poorly on his individual portion of a completely different assignment, she assumes he is simply lazy and unmotivated. This pattern, where a person attributes their own behavior to situational factors but others' behavior to internal traits, is called:

- **A.** Actor-Observer Bias
- **B.** Self-Serving Bias
- **C.** Relative Deprivation
- **D.** Fundamental Attribution Error

6. A quarterback throws for three touchdowns and wins the big game, proudly crediting his own incredible arm strength and hard work in practice, but the following week after a tough loss, he blames the referees' unfair calls instead of his own performance. This pattern of crediting successes to oneself while blaming failures on external factors is called:

- **A.** Fundamental Attribution Error
- **B.** Relative Deprivation
- **C.** Self-Serving Bias
- **D.** Actor-Observer Bias

7. An employee is thrilled after receiving a 5% raise at work, feeling genuinely grateful and appreciated, until she discovers that her coworker with a very similar role and performance history received a 10% raise instead. Even though her own financial situation has objectively improved, she now suddenly feels cheated and undervalued. This phenomenon is called:

- **A.** Relative Deprivation
- **B.** Upward Social Comparison Only
- **C.** The Mere Exposure Effect
- **D.** Self-Serving Bias

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

Source content adapted from Psych Review Hub — Topic 4.1: Attribution Theory and Person Perception (appsychreviewhub.com)